

NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 12

Human Beings Are Stupid

Author

Adelbert Vervloet

Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus ≈ 75 min read aloud
Scenes	15
Version	2026-09-24 · EN-GB dossier after P1

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Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne

Episode 12 — Human Beings Are Stupid

Author Adelbert Vervloet

Logline

Mewtwo walks through Pallet. The bond without blood is not futile. Oak yields the gadgets. Chris touches the hand. Elm: Providence uses the faults. Red on the screen — still there, already less. On Mt. Silver, Mean Look takes the Trainer.

Place in the arc

Due: Oak's favour; Mewtwo; the Red task.

Paid: Mewtwo does not leave; badges as qualities; Chris; Agatha / Lorelei; Red's call.

Open: the gadgets; a Golbat too precise; Red still on the slope.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Gold/Richter · Mewtwo	The hill; the bond without blood
Oak	Expertise; gadgets; the call
Chris/Maria	Route 22; the embrace
Elm / Mike	Silver; selective xenophobia
Agatha / Lorelei	Oak's senility; Lance
Red / Silver	The screen; Mt. Silver; Mean Look / the bench
Quilava / Ponyta	No longer his; no wild reflex

Places (EN anchors)

Pallet Town (streets, hill, Oak's Lab) · Route 22 · New Bark Town (Elm, telephone) · Goldenrod (Mike) · Mt. Silver.

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Heading	Note
Metalepsis	Hospital / Eusine: sensation only. Do not write "Episode 09" in the body.
Being Dracula's Son	OST piece and narrative scene title — keep both distinct in the BGM index. Do not collapse one into the other.
Golbat / Misdreavus	Too precise for a wild specimen. Network left open (no note on the slope).

Screen durations (excluding titles)

Supreme guardian 6 min–6 min 40. Expertise 4 min 20–5. Freedom 50–60 s. Faults / xenophobia ≈ 3 min 50. Senile childishness ≈ 4 min 45. Interception ≈ 3 min 50.

BGM index — pieces (Nocturne OST)

Scene	Piece	Range
Night-Wander / hill	Part of the Same Story	00:00–01:07 · 01:07–end
The hill	Rebellion	00:30–01:00
The hill	Being Dracula's Son	entry
Human Beings Are Stupid	Maria Renard	00:45 · 01:14
Faults / Elm	Don't Leave Me	02:00–02:34
Selective Xenophobia	Sunrise, Sunset	entry
Senile childishness / Agatha	Rebellion	00:00–02:23 · 01:13–02:23
Mt. Silver	Black Eyes	entry · 01:35–end
Mt. Silver	Eclipse	03:04–end

BGM index — traces

Address only.

Scene	BGM
Hill / Mew	EP06 S01 09:00–09:58
Empirical Expertise	EP01 S02 12:00–13:45
Faults / Elm	EP05 S02 03:10–04:00
Senile childishness	EP03 S02 16:50–17:30
The Desolate Interception	EP04 S01 03:47–05:00
The Desolate Interception	EP05 S02 14:12–15:37
Mt. Silver	EP03 S01 15:35–16:22
Mt. Silver	EP04 S02 14:40–15:00

Order of scenes

1. The Familiar Night Wanderer
2. The Humility and Wisdom of the Supreme Guardian
3. Empirical Expertise
4. Precarious Freedom
5. Being Dracula's Son
6. The Conjecture Confirmed
7. The Level Transformed into a Distance of the Heart
8. We Can Be Extravagant Together This Time
9. Contradictory Purity
10. Human Beings Are Stupid
11. The Faults Exploited by Providence
12. Selective Xenophobia
13. The Consequences of Senile Childishness
14. The Desolate Interception
15. The Terror of Organic Savagery

The scenes are inserted here. The close follows the body.

Scene – The Familiar Night Wanderer

Pallet Town – a spring evening, around 7.20 pm

BGM: ‘Part of the Same Story’ 00:00 → 01:07

The wind was cool, almost brisk. It swept through the narrow streets, barely stirring up the dust. The few electric lights cast a faint, yellow glow. A few figures were still about: a man was walking home in silence, two elderly people were chatting in hushed tones by a porch, and a woman was closing the shutters of a shop that was already dark.

It did not feel like any night out of the ordinary.

BGM ‘Part of the Same Story’ 00:21–

Then Mewtwo appeared in the frame, walking at a steady pace. Gold/Richter followed half a body length behind him, hands in his pockets, looking a little too self-conscious.

A few locals looked up.

They did not stop. Just a glance that lingered a little longer than usual — not out of surprise at Mewtwo, but out of slight puzzlement: why was it accompanying him tonight? Why this particular graciousness?

Then they carried on their way, as one does when something is slightly out of the ordinary without being entirely out of place.

—

BGM ‘Part of the Same Story’ 00:37–

The entire journey was not shown.

A lower shot, closer to the ground. Mewtwo’s footsteps, steady, almost indifferent. Gold/Richter’s, slightly out of step, sometimes too short, sometimes too long. A hesitation that was neither mistrust nor refusal. Merely a clumsiness, a subtle unease in the face of an intention he had not yet mastered.

They moved away from the last houses.

The hill on the outskirts was already coming into view, darker than the sky.

BGM ‘Part of the Same Story’ 00:54–

Mewtwo didn’t slow down. Nor did it prepare itself. It seemed ready already, as if the conversation to come required no particular effort on his part.

Gold/Richter, for his part, felt the weight of the imbalance. He was not reluctant, yet the disparity in their preparedness was so great that even the simple act of walking became a burden.

Their silhouettes drew a little closer to the hill.

BGM ‘Part of the Same Story’ 01:02–01:07

Then the image cut out.

End of scene

Scene – The humility and wisdom of the supreme guardian

Hill on the outskirts of Pallet Town *A spring evening, around 8 pm*

The wind had died down. The tall grass barely stirred. Below, the lights of Pallet Town were still visible, but distant.

Mewtwo came to a halt first. Gold/Richter stopped half a step further away, as if he still did not quite dare to stand exactly the same distance apart.

‘You’re surprised, but you’re not wary,’ said Mewtwo. ‘You accepted my invitation despite everything.’

Mewtwo’s voice still didn’t carry through the air. It settled directly upon him.

Gold/Richter replied after a brief silence:

“Not really... I’ve encountered similar situations before. Someone acting with good intentions. Even if I can’t quite remember what they were.”

“That is common, Gold/Richter.”

He showed a very slight flicker of surprise.

“You know my name...”

“Your reputation precedes you.”

Gold/Richter lowered his eyes for a moment.

“My knowledge of you, on the other hand, is very limited. I am ill-prepared. Forgive me.”

“The Professor could not stop speaking of your tales. Your hardships. Your exploits, too.”

“I thought he wasn’t all that interested in me. Because I wasn’t on the same level as Red.”

Mewtwo turned his head slightly.

“He favours Red. Out of remorse, and out of love. Very human.

Yet that does not imply he is uninterested in the one who carries on Red’s legacy. He is rather passionate, in his own way. Even if that way is sometimes outdated for the younger generation.”

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away; he seemed to be seeking solace in those words, without quite finding it.

“I still don’t understand why you intervened. Nor what you heard. Nor which phrase prompted you.”

BGM « Rebellion » 00:30–01:00

Mewtwo remained silent for a moment.

‘Certain issues in your conversation were still too sensitive. You’d already put a great deal of effort into them. And yet, it was still too hasty. For you. And for the Professor, too.

I recognised something I myself had paid dearly for. That is why I felt the need to intervene.”

Gold/Richter nodded slightly.

“Thank you. But... why are you here? And how did things go between you and Red?”

Mewtwo did not reply straight away; it seemed to be searching for the right words.

“Red refused to capture me with the Master Ball. Giovanni wanted to enslave me with it, and with the badge that demands absolute obedience. Red rejected that outcome. So as not to repeat the same mistake. And to restore some sense of dignity to me.”

“How did he manage it... without stirring up your rage?”

“The Physic type is powerful. Not just because of its speed or strength. But because it can act almost instantly, whilst maintaining a distance. An almost absolute advantage.

Those who master it often devise their own techniques alone, so they remain vulnerable to their natural enemies... and sometimes to their own type.

I was no exception. Red had looked into it. He relied on his wits, rather than brute force.”

Gold/Richter murmured:

‘What extravagance...’

“His methods were rarely elegant. Unconventional. Calculated. Pragmatic. Like yours, from what I’ve heard.”

“Me... I’m not really like him. Sometimes I’m more like Green.”

Mewtwo looked at him for a little longer.

“That is no problem. You can envisage the possibility that someone like Green might still form a bond with him. Even if Green could not. You do not face the same obstacles. That difference could help forge a stronger bond.”

Gold/Richter turned his face away slightly.

“You manage to trust us despite your past... simply because of Red’s ethical standards?”

“You’re perceptive. But that’s not enough.”

He paused.

“Red was right to act with greater dignity. Yet, without a certain kind of assistance... the capture and what followed would have remained incomplete.”

Gold/Richter looked up.

“Mew was there...”

“Yes. He didn’t make himself obvious. But I sensed his presence the moment Red defeated me. His intervention soothed my resentment. And prompted me to accept the outcome.

Even though, biologically speaking, I’m not really his brother.”

The silence stretched on.

BGM “EP06 S01 09:00–09:58”

Then Mewtwo continued, in a lower voice:

“God’s cruel wisdom... You’ve committed to treating Red as family. You’re sometimes reluctant to fully acknowledge him, because you still sense a barrier. The Professor feels the same.

I can sense that frustration.”

Gold/Richter did not reply. His eyes merely showed that he had touched upon an old wound.

Mewtwo continued:

‘The day I gained consciousness, I had to come to terms with some ugly realities. I was created from a fragment of Mew. But Mew is neither my brother nor the one who gave birth to me. The scientists who created me were neither gods nor parents.

As a synthetic being, I was neither a true Legendary nor an ordinary Pokémon. That near-supreme power was nothing but a counterfeit. A void.

It filled me with resentment. With bitterness. With a desire for retribution. I ran away, aimlessly, simply to escape this enigma.”

He briefly placed a hand—or what passed for one—on Gold/Richter’s shoulder. The gesture was indecipherable: compassion, a lingering trace of terror, or a simple warning.

“The visceral bond...” said Mewtwo. “For someone like you, who has paid such a high price, it is disappointing to realise that the bond one forges never quite matches that of blood. It isn’t quite fair.

A being as powerful as I have been has strayed because of the lack of that bond.”

Gold/Richter asked, his voice tense:

“So our desire is a luxury... and we’re too privileged?”

“No. I’m not saying that to defend it.

Yet you should know that many beings in this world are fragile and fleeting. Without that bond, most would not have survived. I myself would have committed more serious mistakes, or I would not have escaped certain forms of exploitation... nor the Old Man Coyote.

This bond has its significance. Even if it remains an injustice for those who devote themselves to it as ardently as you do.”

Gold/Richter did not seem any more at ease:

“I see... But how did humans eventually win your trust?”

“Red persuaded me. Morally. And pragmatically, too.”

He looked away slightly.

“Even the legendary ones may need humans to perfect themselves. Techniques, devices, certain structured knowledge... A wild Pokémon, however powerful, cannot access these on its own.”

“Doesn’t that risk reducing our coexistence to mutual exploitation?”

Mewtwo emitted a sound almost like a very dry laugh.

"No doubt. But that's not what I wanted to point out."

He continued, in a more serious tone:

BGM 'Part of the Same Story' 01:07–end

"The Old Man Coyote believes in human potential, but in a distorted form. As for me, I've come to believe in the potential that remains true.

That resonates with your homeland."

"Have you travelled around Johto?"

"Yes. Whilst remaining incognito. And I'm returning there, as agreed."

I was struck by its beauty. Not superficial beauty. A simpler kind of serenity. A fundamental integrity that stems from nothing ostentatious.

Ho-Oh and Lugia... they are probably not as powerful as I am. But they know just how far humans can fall into corruption, and just how high they can rise. They trusted them despite everything. They nurtured a foundation. A tradition.

They aligned themselves with an ancient wisdom. Seeing them, I had to admit my own failings. My status as a victim had only fuelled my anger and my blindness. Not true transcendence.

I was not old enough, nor capable enough, to achieve what they had achieved. I eventually realised that I had only myself to blame."

Gold/Richter asked, almost in spite of himself:

"So you regret it..."

"I used to, yes. Not anymore."

The reply clearly took Gold/Richter by surprise.

'If humans resemble the Creator the most...' said Mewtwo. 'Then perhaps being created by humans is what truly sets me apart. Ironically, it is also my strongest bond with you.

And the bond with Mew has given me enough time to learn to watch over others. My adversity hasn't been entirely in vain. Dr Fuji paid a price, too. A costly lesson... but a valuable one."

'Why didn't you go with Red, then?'

Mewtwo lowered his voice slightly.

"I'm sorry I couldn't help him more. It all happened too suddenly after we met. He asked me to keep an eye on Kanto in case an evil too powerful were to re-emerge there. I promised him I would."

He paused for a long moment:

BGM 'Being Dracula's Son'

"We're all part of this world. We can't isolate ourselves indefinitely. Even though I was only recently born, I've already seen how quickly everything changes. We can't fix everything. But if we don't do what we can within our own means, it'll be too late.

I want to bear witness to this. I must.

Ironically... I, who have scorned humans, will one day have to learn not to be too pained by their deaths. I'll have to find a compromise."

The tone was almost that of an inside joke. Gold/Richter felt slightly reassured.

Then he asked, in a lower voice:

'But... is the bloodless bond really so insignificant? So futile?'

"That's not my view."

Gold/Richter looked up, startled by the glimmer in those words.

"Many beings are abandoned, even when there is a blood bond," said Mewtwo. "If Mew had abandoned me in the same way, I wouldn't have made it through.

A visceral bond that is uncultivated, or poorly cultivated, is worth almost nothing. That is why I intervened. Not to tell you that this bond is equal to blood. But so that you would stop underestimating it."

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment.

A flashback: in the hospital scene from episode 09, Eusine mentions something similar. Gold/Richter can only recall the sense of sincerity and truthfulness in Eusine's words. The exact content remains a blur.

"Nevertheless... that means you won't be coming with me," Gold/Richter surmised.

"No. I'm sorry.

Red deserves to see just how much his non-blood-related family has flourished. And that a new driving force has emerged in Johto... one capable, perhaps, of breaking the cycle."

Gold/Richter tilted his head slightly.

"...Thank you. By the way... how is your relationship with Mew?"

Mewtwo looked away, his gaze fixed on some indeterminate point in the darkness.

"I've come across him a few times. Sometimes, I merely sense his presence. Probably even now."

Gold/Richter followed the direction of his gaze. He could make out nothing clear. After a moment, he gave up trying.

In the distance, at the edge of the field, a very discreet presence seemed to be watching before blending back into the night.

End of scene

Scene – Empirical Expertise

Professor Oak's Laboratory – Pallet Town *A spring evening, around 8.10 pm*

The laboratory stood in the twilight like a grand mansion, somewhat too large for the village. The air was cool, almost cold for spring. A scent of damp earth and fallen leaves wafted amongst the trees.

Professor Oak stood near the entrance. He was wearing a dark pelisse, his hands clasped behind his back, as if trying to shake off a persistent unease. He had stepped away from the building for a moment, with no particular purpose in mind.

Then two figures appeared in the distance, on the path.

Mewtwo led the way, with Gold/Richter a little behind. When they were within a reasonable distance, Mewtwo stopped.

'I apologise for that unexpected gesture.'

He turned his head slightly towards Oak.

Oak regarded him without any real surprise.

"Your presence is no longer all that surprising. Your motive, on the other hand..."

Mewtwo gave a slight nod.

"All the better. Well then, I'll be off."

He took just a few steps back. Enough to no longer intrude on their conversation. Not enough to disappear. His curiosity was neither satisfied nor abandoned. He simply stepped back.

Oak turned his attention back to Gold/Richter. His mistrust had not vanished, but it had eased.

"So... is your decision still firm?"

Gold/Richter nodded. The movement was subtle, yet hesitant. Oak saw it clearly. He already knew he no longer had the power to stop him.

"The problem isn't just whether you're capable of defeating Red.

It's also what you would become... even if you did succeed."

Gold/Richter looked up slightly.

"Are you concerned about my fate...?"

The question held Oak's attention. He did not reply straight away.

Gold/Richter continued, in a lower voice:

"That I'll become the second Red...?"

A flicker of unease crossed Oak's face. A vague, unresolved sense of guilt:

"If by that you mean remorse... I cannot deny it."

Gold/Richter lowered his gaze for a moment.

"Yes. That is what I constantly fear."

Oak stared at him for a little longer. He could see there was no romanticisation in it. Only a specific fear.

"Bear in mind that my assessment may be wrong. Red was more accomplished than Green, in an inherent way..."

I am not exaggerating his ability. He may not have been the strongest among the candidates. But holistically, he was.

He did not stand out at first glance, for access to resources and the capacity to dedicate oneself to them count just as much as natural talent. The same was true of Giovanni.

Red was not spared from having to balance this disparity. He invested a great deal of effort in doing so.

Green judged him more on the basis of his combat results than on those criteria.

‘Your approaches are innovative. Effective. But I’m not sure they’re enough to make up for what Red has endured.’

Gold/Richter made no attempt to defend himself.

“I am aware of that. My proposal is not exactly a fraud... yet it remains morally ambiguous.

Yet to bridge this gap I cannot be left without information.”

Oak regarded him more seriously.

“Without it, would you lose your courage?”

Gold/Richter did not reply immediately. His face had darkened.

BGM ‘EP01 S02 12:00–13:45’

“There is something that troubles me more than the lack of information.”

Oak observed this change. He sensed, vaguely, that there were deeper reasons at play.

Gold/Richter continued, in a calmer voice:

“Professor... you have made mistakes.

But had you not corrected yourself, had you not rediscovered the connection between science, methodology and spirituality...

I would not have survived Team Rocket, nor the Old Man Coyote.

I know my limits all too well.”

He reached inside his jacket and pulled out several metal objects. The Johto badges.

“These badges are not mere rewards. Not for me, nor for us.

Each one embodies a quality that the Gym Leader personifies, and which already lies dormant within each of us.

I did not gain my strength or fight alone.”

Then he took out some more badges. Misty’s. Green’s. Blaine’s.

“These, too, are no longer mere trophies.

Times are changing. Even in Kanto. Slowly.

Some Gym Leaders, like Blaine, have changed. Or have never given in.

We are adapting to it.

If I were still clinging to the old ways... I would almost certainly lose to Red.

But with your help, the outcome might be different.”

He paused. A wistful hesitation flitted across his face. Oak saw it, and it seemed to weigh upon him.

Gold/Richter continued, in a lower voice:

‘Whatever you decide, I will go along with it. Please just bear that in mind.

Yet... if I am not merely worthy of being a Pokédex holder.

I am also, to a certain extent, an heir to your legacy.

I would be grateful if you would deign to grant this request.”

He lowered his gaze slightly as he said this. The unease was palpable. So was the hesitation.

Oak did not reply. His gaze had grown intense. He was seeking neither a quick retort nor an immediate resolution.

Standing back, Mewtwo remained motionless. He did not intervene. But the acrimony of the exchange seemed to affect him despite the distance.

Silence fell. Unresolved.

End of scene

Scene – Precarious Freedom

Route 22 – Kanto *Late spring morning*

The light was crisp, almost harsh. Tall grass lined the path. Further on, the trees let a gentle breeze through.

Chris/Maria walked at a steady pace. Venomoth followed her at shoulder height, its wings barely spread. She surveyed her surroundings without haste. Every encounter was noted, weighed up. There was neither excitement nor carelessness in her demeanour.

A rustle—too sharp, too close—made her stop.

Venomoth froze instantly. Chris/Maria turned her head towards a dense bush, set slightly back from the path. She did not approach straight away. A few seconds passed.

Only then did they move forward.

At first, almost nothing. Then a low, motionless shape. A very faint whimper, closer to surprise than to pain.

The bush parted before their eyes.

A Ponyta was there.

It was unharmed. Its coat was clean, its breathing steady. Yet everything about its proportions remained childlike. Its legs were a little too thin, its hooves still too wide for its body, its mane short

and limp, almost lacking any body. It didn't really try to run away. It merely took a clumsy step backwards, then stopped, eyes wide open, showing no apparent instinct.

Chris/Maria stood still.

She observed its size, its posture, the total absence of any wild reflexes. It was not a newborn. Nor was it a young one already capable of fending for itself.

Venomoth remained at a distance, its antennae slightly raised.

Chris/Maria held the Ponyta's gaze for a moment. Her face showed neither overt pity nor anger. Only a harsher, more inward focus.

She said nothing.

She took it all in.

Then she slowly looked away, without drawing any conclusions.

End of scene

Scene – Being Dracula's Son

, Pallet Town *Late spring, the light still bright*

A bench set slightly apart, almost unused. The grass was tall at the edges of the path. The air already carried the approaching warmth of summer, without quite being there yet.

Silver and Gold/Richter sat side by side, without touching. Feraligatr stood a little way back, massive and calm. Quilava stood further away, to one side, neither hostile nor friendly.

Silver spoke first, getting straight to the point.

"So... has that Pokémon become yours again?"

Gold/Richter shook his head slightly.

"Since I've been back here, I'm sometimes entrusted with training certain Pokémon from the laboratory. Including Quilava.

I'm no longer its Trainer."

His gaze drifted for a moment towards the creature. Quilava stood near Feraligatr, completely at ease. Something inside Gold/Richter's chest briefly relaxed — the relief of knowing it had been spared. Then Quilava turned its head towards him. Gold/Richter looked away. The relief vanished immediately, giving way to something else.

"You're bolder than people realise... Once a starter. Now a Pokédex. Incredible."

Silver did not smile.

"Professor Elm has completely called off the investigation. In that respect, I owe him a great deal. And also the data on Feraligatr... the data I'd almost collected.

If those were your original missions...'

"Even Professor Oak isn't really pursuing it any more," replied Gold/Richter. "Don't worry."

Silence fell. Not awkward, just there.

Silver continued, in a lower voice:

'So you've made up your mind... to head for Red?'

"Yes. I'm sorry. That means I'll have to face the man who contributed to your misfortune."

He said this with obvious unease, making no attempt to hide it.

Silver stared at a point in front of him.

"I thought I hated Red. Because he'd ruined my life.

But that does not change the fact that the real culprit was Giovanni. None of it really had anything to do with him. It became a way of projecting my anger onto someone else. After my trip to Johto, I realised that."

Gold/Richter turned his head slightly.

"Why the change of heart? And the Pokédex... will you use it to take revenge on Giovanni?"

"Certainly, for that, intelligence and resources are essential. But that's not the only reason."

There was a serious pause in his voice. Gold/Richter noticed it.

Silver continued:

BGM 'Being Dracula's Son'

"You were right. Children should not have to bear the burden of their father's sins. Yet... children born into such circumstances, from such a lineage... rarely end up well. More often than not, they end up in depravity. As for the others, saving them is far more demanding than saving their parents. And in a more depraved society, these children are destined for a miserable end."

He paused.

"After my escapade, I realised just how much harm people in Johto could have suffered... or already had. Professor Elm had vouched for me. The Kimono Girls... I was given the chance to travel through Johto, where they agreed to grant me limited tolerance and to set me straight. The price was steep. Providence deigned to break that trajectory."

Gold/Richter spoke almost in spite of himself:

"It was also because you were braver than us in facing the imprecation."

"No. You're mistaken."

"Modesty isn't really your style."

Silver shook his head.

"I'm not humble enough to deny my part in it. But if you hadn't tried to break that structural rivalry between the starters, I would have had to settle for hollow, meaningless victories... and I would have ended up like Green.

Without Umbreon and Espeon, I would not have emerged from the shadows into the light. Thanks also to Professor Elm. To you. Even to Red.”

A longer silence.

Then Silver added, almost as an aside:

“God’s cruel wisdom... as you say.

It gets you down. For me, it’s turned out differently.”

“How so?”

BGM: ‘Family in Heart’ 00:11–

“The blood did me no good. But Red, on the other hand... he saved the son of his worst enemy. Indirectly. That outcome led me to Johto. To you all. It spared me from a fate, from irreversible sins, from becoming like Giovanni.

Looking back... I’m grateful to him for that. A joy in life.”

Gold/Richter regarded him askance.

“So you’re aiming to defeat Giovanni out of some lingering love...?”

“I cannot define it. Not yet.”

“If Giovanni were to face justice... would you expect him to reform? Or to love you again?”

The question weighed heavily. Gold/Richter did not seem to believe it himself.

Silver replied bluntly:

“No. I don’t think justice could save him. Even Red couldn’t stop him.

Yet if that visceral bond truly prevailed... at least I would halt him by shattering it. I hope so.

Accepting a Pokédex is my way of taking on responsibility and repaying Johto’s generosity.”

Gold/Richter murmured, almost without a voice:

“How ironic... You’re taking on Giovanni. I’m taking on Red... the strongest.”

“So I cannot let you take on Giovanni as well. Otherwise it would be too much for you to bear.”

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment.

“What troubles me... is not so much that he is the strongest. It is the kind of person Red has become.”

Silver made no attempt to downplay it.

“I am not underestimating your burden. If Giovanni is the worst, Red cannot possibly be the strongest of the villains. You can at least take some comfort in that.”

He did not look entirely convinced.

At that moment, Quilava approached. It stopped in front of Gold/Richter. Its demeanour was not hostile. Merely attentive, as if it were reading something on the former trainer’s face.

Gold/Richter stood motionless. Then, after a clear hesitation, he held out his hand slightly. Not quite a gesture of reconciliation. More like an incomplete acceptance.

Something bitter and lucid flashed across his eyes. A hard-won satisfaction. Like tears that no longer needed to fall.

Silver watched the scene unfold without intervening.

‘Your efforts are evident. Even if they remain austere. And more fruitful than they appear.’

Gold/Richter replied after a moment:

“Yes... We’ve managed to protect them.”

All around them the atmosphere remained calm. They were still young. And yet, something in the way they sat side by side gave the impression that they had already, without even trying, sheltered a little of what was to come.

End of scene

Scene — The Conjecture Confirmed

Route 22 — Kanto *Late spring light*

BGM: ‘Powerful Predatory Deadly’ 00:00–00:46

The grass was tall and already warm. There was hardly a breath of wind. Chris/Maria walked along unhurriedly, Venomoth perched on her shoulder. She was taking notes. Not with joy. With that somewhat laboured precision she now reserved for collecting samples.

A rustle – too sharp, too close – made her stop.

Venomoth froze immediately. They approached the bush without haste.

At first, almost nothing. Then a low, motionless shape. Two heads too small for the body. Feathers still soft. Eyes too large.

Doduo.

It wasn’t injured. Nor had it been abandoned recently. But everything about its proportions remained childlike. Its legs were too thin. Its gaze too wide-eyed. A total lack of bravery.

Chris/Maria crouched down slightly. Slow movements. Open hands. Nothing threatening.

Doduo took a clumsy step back. Then another. Its breathing quickened for no apparent reason.

She tried again. Lower. Calmer.

He didn’t understand.

Its body tensed all at once. The left head dropped. A convulsive, uncoordinated, almost involuntary movement — **Drill Peck**.

Chris/Maria spun round. The beak whizzed past her shoulder, just a few centimetres away. She hadn’t even straightened up completely. The reading appeared on the leveller: 04.

She stood motionless.

Venomoth took half a step forward, a pure, protective presence. Doduo saw him. Misinterpreted it.

This time the movement was wider, more spectacular, but just as unbalanced. **Brave Bird**. A lunge that had neither the strength nor the precision of what it claimed to be. A gesture that transcended the animal itself.

Venomoth dodged it effortlessly. Its wings spread. A fine dust fell.

Doduo collapsed almost immediately. Gullible. Without a fight.

Silence returned.

Chris/Maria did not emerge from the Poké Ball. She gazed at the slumbering body for a long while. Not with pity. Not with anger.

With that ominous, almost physical sensation, which did not come from the creature, but from what the phenomenon revealed.

She'd expected to find something. She'd found it. And it brought her no relief whatsoever.

She rose to her feet. Venomoth followed. They walked away without a word.

End of scene

Scene — The Level Transformed into a Distance of the Heart

, Viridian City Late spring light, verging on summer

The bench was warm. The shade of the trees had not quite fallen yet. Green and Gold/Richter were sitting there, a little too upright for such a relaxed setting. The silence had already grown heavy.

Green spoke first, without really looking at him.

'You're too clever to go along with these preparations...'

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. He was not boasting about anything. His ambivalence was still evident in the way his hands lay open on his lap.

"...I won't really be able to avoid challenging Red...?"

Green nodded ever so slightly.

"I'm afraid so. Red is here... to be subjected to a imprecation. That of being the strongest."

A moment passed.

Gold/Richter turned his face slightly.

"Say... Green. There's this question I keep having..."

Green was taken aback by the abruptness. Yet his expression didn't harden. It was almost inviting.

"It's not about deserting. Why don't people as strong as Lance and you... go there to challenge Red? It's a daft question. But I'd like to hear it from you yourselves. Red's team isn't all that overpowered, according to their entities. Yours... are the exact opposite."

Green paused. It wasn't hesitation. He was waiting.

A voice came from behind him.

"Because force alone... doesn't solve everything."

BGM "EP 05 S02 01:20–02:48"

Gold/Richter started. Green had not moved.

Lance approached. He didn't sit down straight away. He stood there for a moment, looking at the light over the square, as if still weighing up whether he should speak.

"I've been summoned by Green... to do you a favour. We're strong, yes. Statistically... we'd manage it. But we owe it to him. To Red."

Lance continued:

"Whilst we were... holding back, he held his ground. He even ended up beating us. Even though we thought he was weaker.

If we beat him now simply by raising the stakes... we wouldn't be setting him free. We'd merely be taking away... what he's achieved. It would almost be an insult. Ruining him rather than saving him.

Green spoke again, more quietly.

"There are knots... that you can't untie yourself. You need someone else. So we'll stay. We'll keep watch. We'll wait for him to come back... whilst being the strongest in other ways."

Gold/Richter frowned slightly.

"But doesn't that make things worse...? You stay at the same level... whilst his keeps rising."

Lance finally sat down, a little way off.

"Indeed. To shield the others from this imprecation, to ensure he never loses to anyone, he keeps piling it up. And that level... has become something else. A distance. Hardly anyone can reach it now. They don't have the means."

Gold/Richter looked at them one after the other.

"...You've been waiting. For a long time. For it to be me."

Lance felt a vague, almost awkward sense of shame.

"It had to be someone who owed him nothing. I couldn't bring myself to ask you. Even now... I can't really bring myself to push you into it."

Gold/Richter took a deep breath.

"All right. But I'm not... without debt either. Not in the same way. And beating him... it's not the same as fighting you, Green."

Green emitted a sound akin to laughter, yet devoid of joy.

BGM “EP03 S02 08:10–08:50”

“The problem isn’t winning. It’s what we break in the process when we win like that. Even against evil.”

Lance nodded.

“It was the same for Red. Like his flame. He managed to tear things down without taking everything with him. That’s why he held out where we failed.

Strength that’s too perfect... it seems solid. But on the inside, it becomes fragile. It can shut itself off. It can even... be imitated. We’ve learnt that, Cher.”

Green placed his hands flat on the wooden bench.

“Those who must, always end up seeing their own limits. Even after they’ve got back on their feet. I realised that after what you did for me...

Some forms of redemption... end up costing more than they make amends for. If one isn’t as clear-sighted and broad-minded as you.

Then we give in. To those who come after us. Even if it’s too heavy a burden. Even if it’s disproportionate.”

Gold/Richter looked ahead, towards the still-bright square.

“I will take care of this. But you should know that I have only one chance to succeed. And that it concerns the safety of my Pokémon. So... I will need you to train me and do me this favour.”

Lance finally looked him straight in the eye.

“You can take some of the pressure off yourself. There are others. More experienced ones. They’ve already agreed.”

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. His surprise remained visible, though contained. He did not yet know who they were.

Silence fell once more. The late spring light continued to fall on Viridian, almost indifferently.

End of scene

Scene — We Can Be Extravagant Together This Time

Viridian City, outdoor café — late spring light, almost summer

The shadows cast by the awnings were still short. The air already smelled of warm grass and lukewarm tarmac. On the table, two barely touched cups.

Blue glanced sideways at Chris/Maria, her body turned slightly towards her, as if the question needed to force its way through a little.

“So... why do you have these capture rules at your place...?”

BGM “EP03 S02 08:50–10:17”

Chris/Maria did not reply straight away. Her fingers lingered for a moment on the rim of the cup.

"It's... the first impression. The one they'll have as soon as we've caught them. If that's compromised, their relationship with humans... gets bogged down. Even if we've caught a strong individual. I think it works the same way with us."

Blue said nothing. His eyes had grown glassy.

A moment passed.

"...Very well. What impression has Kanto given you... so far...?"

Chris/Maria lowered her gaze slightly towards the arena.

"... Too inscrutable. Here, the Trainers are, on average, more powerful. The wild ones... so weak. There are even Pokémon that have evolved to surprisingly low levels. Venomoth. Arbok. Noctowl. Ariados. Fearow. As if this world had come to a standstill. Stagnated."

She took a breath.

"This region is a grave... rather than the one saved by Red. Far too gloomy."

Blue could find nothing to say in reply. She merely tilted her head, almost imperceptibly.

Gold/Richter and Green approached. They sat down without making too much noise.

Blue spoke more quietly, as if the words were meant first and foremost for herself.

"...I don't know if my support will have the opposite effect..."

Then, more clearly:

"I spoke to Red about that idiot's business. And I also wanted him to be happy. But trying to achieve both... that was an act of excessive pride. Clearly."

Gold/Richter looked at her.

"... You don't want that anymore...?"

Blue shook her head slightly.

"Yes. But I do not know if it would make any difference this time. Two wishes... that might already be too many. Oh well."

Gold/Richter hesitated.

"If I'm being too frank... what's it like, that feeling towards someone you've stopped loving... whilst still wishing them well... Sorry. We're not old enough to have had enough experience."

Blue hesitated for a moment, then pushed past him.

BGM: "EP04 S01 22:40–24:12"

"If we'd thought we'd fallen for the wrong person, it would have made everything so much simpler. But someone who wasn't right for me... who was meant only for the other person, and I for someone else... it's more complicated.

Yet loving a good person... even by mistake, even through projection... is not something you can simply cut out without a cost.

It is no longer residual love. It is the very ability to appreciate those who are good, and to love the one who is meant for you.

I cannot detach myself from Red's fate without touching on that. Even if it still stirs up jealousy.

That is the price one pays for not losing the way one loves."

Green, without a word, reached out and placed her hand against Blue's. Then, very gently, she rested her own head against Blue's. Not an ostentatious caress. A gentle rest. A relational duty she accepted, despite the visible reluctance in her shoulders.

"Granting two wishes was asking too much... But your extravagance, your daring... shielded Red from my foolishness.

And this time... you might not be the only one to commit this folly. There would be others."

Blue closed her eyes for a moment. She recognised the partial truth in those words. Her remorse ceased to deepen. A resigned sense of consolation took its place.

Gold/Richter and Chris/Maria remained silent. A sense of relief flitted across their faces, but the worry had not vanished. It had merely shifted.

The late spring light continued to fall on the café tables, almost indifferently.

End of scene

Scene — Contradictory Purity

Pallet Town: Red's House — Late Spring Light

Outside, the air was already warm. The trees lining the road stood almost still. Gold/Richter stopped at the door.

Red's mother appeared. She said nothing. A simple, open gesture of the hand was enough. Permission granted. She walked away towards the kitchen.

He went upstairs.

BGM 'EP07 S01 09:50–10:35'

The bedroom.

He'd expected dust. Canvases. The ashes of visible neglect.

What he found was something else entirely.

Everything was spotless. The sheets were pulled taut without a single crease. The shelves were dusted. The objects were arranged with an almost cold precision. No trace of disorder. No recent marks. A purity that was utterly lifeless.

Gold/Richter stepped forward slowly. He was looking for traces. For personal touches. For remnants of frenzy, of passion, of choice. He found almost none.

The past was there, sober, austere, but indecipherable. Nothing that spoke of the Trainer. Nothing that spoke of the present. No photograph of the father. No notes. No obvious personal preferences.

He pulled a drawer out as far as it would go.

At the back, a green Badge.

He stared at it for a long time. Without touching it. The hope he still clung to slowly closed in on him.

He went back downstairs.

At the table, the tea had already been served. Two cups. A few simple biscuits.

Gold/Richter picked up his spoon and swirled it in the liquid, without really looking at it.

The mother spoke first.

‘How are your parents? Do you keep in touch with them often?’

Gold/Richter replied without looking up.

“...Yes. Chris/Maria and I get in touch with them regularly. But... there isn’t much to say, to be honest.”

She looked at him. She saw his reserve. She didn’t press him.

“We... parents... Once our children have left, we can’t really help them any more. We haven’t seen enough of the world. The world is changing too fast. It drives people apart.”

A silence.

Then, in a lower voice:

“Are you disappointed...?”

Gold/Richter shook his head slightly.

“No. It’s just... Red’s room is contradictory. Almost free of dust, ash, marks, cobwebs. So still. But that purity... foreshadows a loneliness. A sadness.”

BGM ‘Making Monsters’ 00:48–

The mother waited a few seconds.

“I clean this room... so that it isn’t too messy when she comes back. But that day hasn’t come yet. And I don’t know when it will.”

She said nothing more.

The silence that followed required no reply. Gold/Richter felt it settle in his chest, heavy and inescapable.

There was nothing he could do about it.

End of scene

Scene — Human Beings Are Stupid

Pallet Town. *Quiet streets — late spring light, almost summer*

The air was warm. Few passers-by. The shadows of the houses were already lengthening slightly.

Chris/Maria/Maria and Gold/Richter strolled at a leisurely pace.

Gold/Richter spoke first, in a light, almost peaceful tone.

‘So, what have you discovered?’

Chris/Maria did not smile. She took out a Poké Ball and spun it once between her fingers.

“...Some Pokémon. Too weak to survive in the wild.”

She held up the ball.

BGM “EP01 S01 25:36–27:04”

“This one. Drill Peck. Brave Bird too. Inherited moves...”

Gold/Richter paused for a moment. He understood before she went on.

‘... It was... hatched from an egg. And abandoned.’

“Yes. Because they’re no use in battle. Even with that. Oak confirmed it. Here... we release them much more readily than in Johto.”

She continued, in a lower voice.

“In Johto, they make mistakes too. But there’s still... certain things. A sort of restraint. Here, it’s more... mixed. Even the shelters get overcrowded sometimes.”

Gold/Richter was at a loss for words.

Chris/Maria continued.

“Houndoom. Murkrow. Invasive species here. We released them without a second thought. They’ve adapted. They’ve proliferated.

If your story is true... Old Man Coyote doesn’t need to intervene himself. All he has to do is channel our vices. These Pokémon illustrate that all too perfectly.”

She paused.

“So... I’m thinking of bringing my journey here to an early end.”

Gold/Richter nodded. His regret was evident, though restrained.

“All right. Thank you for accompanying me.”

Chris/Maria looked ahead.

“This journey has been worthwhile. Even if it wasn’t... pleasant. Not all people are bad. But most of them... they stick to what they know. Few really dare to stand in the way when someone needs protecting. That’s what... saddens me the most.”

She paused for a moment.

"I won't be coming back here. Unless... our big brother returns. I'm sorry. I should have seen it through to the end with you."

"Don't feel obliged. I'm not alone here."

Chris/Maria scanned the street. A wistful look of wonder crossed her face.

"...Still, to my amazement... there's such a picturesque town in Kanto. Just like ours.

I'm glad I got to see Red's hometown. So beautiful... it goes some way towards explaining his exceptional qualities."

Gold/Richter replied without harshness.

"...But not everyone here is like him."

"No. But he's an exception in a place that allowed him to be one. That... is enough."

A pause. A slight awkwardness.

Chris/Maria continued, almost teasingly.

"I stand corrected... You haven't really changed that much. But enough that we're struggling to recognise you... in a strange way."

Gold/Richter looked away.

BGM: 'EP06 S02 00:30–01:50'

"I know what it cost you. To stay with someone like me. The patience. The expectations. Too much, for your age. Just because... I couldn't do without that need any longer. It's... too much."

Chris/Maria gave a very faint smile.

"You're not the only one who needs to be loved."

Gold/Richter looked at her, surprised.

She continued, more calmly.

"You're hiding behind your guilt. But the love you feel... it's different. More precise. Warmer. Not because you've remained unscathed. Because you've been through it all.

It is hard to stand at your side. But it is not in vain.

Your clumsiness. The way you are... too proper. The trauma. The shame. All of that... it has shaped you too. The modesty. The perseverance. That slightly rigid discipline. Without them, you would not be... the way you are. Nor would your love. I must not do away with them."

Gold/Richter asked, almost under his breath:

'So... what am I supposed to do with them?'

"You just have to accept them as part of yourself. Turn them into a bond with others. Don't let them distort you. Even if you don't overcome them... you can carry them. Refine them. Stay with others so that they don't consume you on their own. That's already... a lot.

Most people haven't made it this far. You can at least... talk about them. Otherwise we learn nothing. Human beings remain stupid."

A longer silence.

Chris/Maria continued.

"At first... I might have been pretending. Pretending to forgive you. Then I saw Misty. What she'd been through. And I understood why you'd chosen that path. I... I wouldn't have had that courage. So I can't really hold it against you anymore."

Gold/Richter said:

"Sometimes... being right doesn't make anything better."

"Sometimes, the times are so cruel. We're all caught up in them. Even those who've paid a high price, suffered so much, gained a greater clarity... must face their own mortality and cannot find a solution that satisfies everyone."

Gold/Richter hesitated.

'... I realised you'd be happier with the others. Not with me.'

Chris/Maria shook her head slightly.

'I heard. But... given what happened... I don't think I would have been any happier. Even if I'd been hurt. Blue was right.'

She paused.

BGM 'Maria Renard'

"We always imagine that without the clash, everything would have been better. It's just a fantasy.

If you'd stayed... we might have been together. But Johto... wouldn't have lasted. It would all have come to an end.

You chose differently. You defeated Apollo. You held back the darkness. Otherwise, all of this could have been reduced to nothing.

I'm hurt. Of course. It's an imperfect compromise. But we've held on. It's painful. Yet we aren't separated for good.

Now I have realised... that this is God's wisdom. And His mercy. I am grateful to Him. So very much."

The bitterness had not entirely left Gold/Richter's face.

"That does not justify what I did to you. I do not deserve for you to forgive me so quickly."

Chris/Maria looked him straight in the eye.

"It's not forgiveness you're seeking."

The words shook him, but did not break him.

BGM 'Maria Renard' 00:45–

"You just don't want our bond to be severed. I know your reasons. The consequences. The outcomes. They're messy. Enough is enough."

She brushed against his bare hand.

Gold/Richter flinched in surprise. Before, he would have felt ashamed. This time, he didn't pull his hand away. Something powerful welled up inside him — still incomplete, but present.

Tears welled up. Along with a smile. Warm.

Chris/Maria spoke more softly.

BGM 'Maria Renard' 01:14—

"Red is still suffering, just like you. To bring him back, you can't remain as incomplete as you were before.

I'll be waiting for you in Johto. And bring our brother back with you. There's still more to come between us."

Gold/Richter looked at her through his tears.

"I'll return... with him. I still wish to savour the happiness in my life... even if it is imperfect. This time... I do not wish to miss it."

They embraced.

A rare sense of contentment. Eyes closed. Gold/Richter's tears continued to fall, slowly, whilst the view of Pallet remained pristine behind them.

End of scene

Scene — The Faults Exploited by Providence

Telephone conversation: *Professor Elm — New Bark Town Laboratory; Gold/Richter — Pallet Town*
Late spring light

Gold/Richter spoke first.

'Did you have a good chat with Silver...?'

A faint rustling of paper on the other end.

"Yes. The stolen Pokémon has thrived. That's the most credible evidence. I have little to object to. The case is settled."

A pause.

"Have you prepared yourself properly...? To set off?"

"No. The procedures are more complicated than one might think. So I can only ask you to look after Chris... as soon as he returns, and whilst I'm away. Otherwise, I won't be able to get the relief I need."

"You can count on it."

Gold/Richter detected a waver in the voice, something that was not quite at ease.

"What's on your mind, Professor...?"

Elm paused for a moment before replying.

BGM “EP05 S02 03:10–04:00”

“This case... weighed on me more than it appeared to. Silver proved to be more decent. But I made a decision that was almost ridiculous given my position, my clarity of thought, and the public eye.

If it had gone wrong... I could have made matters worse for a young man who had already suffered so much. Or rendered our relationship... irreparable. Even with... the intercession. It was a delicate matter.”

He seemed to be searching for a sense of peace that he could not find.

“However hard I tried... I wasn’t able to protect our children. Probably because I haven’t been around as long as Professor Oak.”

Gold/Richter replied without hesitation.

“No. You were right.”

“I cannot justify that decision so rashly.”

“Certainly not.”

Me too... I insisted on stopping Silver. For the sake of justice. But I eventually realised that justice, when applied too rigidly... doesn’t always work. I hadn’t fully considered the consequences.

On the road... facing Team Rocket... I was not fully aware either of what I was putting Chris – and myself – through.

And yet... that limited clarity saved us. You included. Providence made use of our flaws.

I understand your reasons. I can find no grounds to blame you.’

A longer silence.

BGM ‘Don’t Leave Me’ 02:00–02:34

“That is divine wisdom,” said Gold/Richter. “Even if people aren’t clear-sighted enough... if they take responsibility, it can make all the difference. Sparing a young life from misery.

You’re young compared to Professor Oak. But you were brave. To stand up for Silver. To look out for the other children. Truly.

To Chris and me... even to Silver... you’re a real hero. A rather stern one, even.”

Elm replied without false modesty, nor with any real rejection.

“I don’t think I really deserve that title.”

Gold/Richter exhaled, almost embarrassed.

‘... No doubt. But I can’t think of a better way to express these feelings and our gratitude. I’m sorry.’

On the other end of the line there was silence. Then something that resembled a restrained smile – invisible, yet perceptible.

They fell silent. Each had sensed the other’s acceptance.

The conversation hung in the air, with no closing words.

End of scene

Scene — Selective Xenophobia

Goldenrod City / Pallet Town Telephone conversation — late spring light

Over in Goldenrod, the afternoon was drawing out. Cups were still lukewarm. Electrode stood motionless by the table. A little further away, Krise's Jigglypuff was barely puffing out its cheeks, whilst Bryan's Hoothoot blinked slowly and the Pidgey pecked at fallen crumbs.

The handset vibrated.

Gold/Richter, in Pallet, spoke first.

"You're as talkative and curious as ever... Are you that fascinated by life abroad?"

Mike's voice came across calm, almost distracted.

"I'm not keen on foreign places."

"Xenophobia, then...?"

"Even less so. I want to learn about what happens there. But primarily through the people around me. Otherwise... those experiences wouldn't have been so fascinating if they'd never been there themselves."

Gold/Richter let out a short sigh.

"You're such a stickler..."

Mike did not reply straight away; he seemed to be weighing something up in the silence of Gold's words.

"You've opened up quite a bit. That means your relationship with Chris/Maria has come a long way."

A blush crept up despite the distance. Gold/Richter lowered his voice slightly.

"...Yes."

He said it as if he were admitting to a transgression.

Mike continued without pressing the issue.

"No need to be embarrassed. Without that, the task would have been overwhelming."

Gold/Richter hesitated.

"Mike... my words have sometimes been too heavy. Too philosophical. It wasn't to show off. Nor to come across as... pedantic."

Mike said nothing, but his attention had sharpened.

Gold/Richter continued, in a lower voice.

BGM 'Sunrise, Sunset'

"I've become someone I didn't want to be at first. Yet you welcomed me. Despite everything."

I'm grateful. I really am. I've learnt that I can't get by without people like you.

So many complicated things happen to me. I want to sort them out. Find better solutions. That... makes me feel awkward."

Mike asked the question straight out.

"You didn't want to be that way. So you hate what you've become...?"

Gold/Richter seemed to sit up slightly, as if in response to a specific question.

"...I didn't know. I thought I hated it because it had robbed me of what I'd thought I wanted."

"And now?"

"... I've been able to accept it more. I haven't really lost everything. After all."

Mike gave a slight nod, even though Gold/Richter could not see him.

'There you go. So that's all sorted.'

He cast a discreet glance towards Krise, Bryan and the other Trainers around the table. The Jigglypuff rolled slightly onto its side. Hoothoot turned its head.

"Do you want me to pass on any messages to the others...?" asked Mike.

Gold/Richter remained silent for several seconds. Then his voice returned, sounding a little more confident.

"No. I'll tell them myself. As soon as I get back."

Mike gave a serene, almost gentle smile. Gold/Richter didn't see it.

The conversation hung in the air for a moment, then came to an end without any unnecessary formalities.

End of scene

Scene — The consequences of senile childishness

, Pallet Town. In front of Oak's laboratory — spring twilight

The light was fading. The air remained mild, almost summer-like. Oak and Gold/Richter stood near the entrance to the laboratory.

Oak handed over the agreed gadgets. Their purpose was unclear. His tone was reserved and serious.

'Here you are. Solicitude honoured.'

Gold/Richter took them.

"Thank you so much for making an exception... But why the change of heart?"

Oak regarded him for a moment.

"I've come to understand your intentions better. Including your concerns."

Gold/Richter hesitated, then asked:

“...By any chance... did you draft Dr Fuji’s thesis? And what is the gist of it, if I may ask?”

BGM “EP03 S02 16:50–17:30”

Oak replied without haste.

“I was already working with vague concepts. This process forced me to give them concrete form.

Its essence: Providence manifests its wisdom through imperfect beings. Science. Technology. Art. Yet we are prone to confuse these with wonders inherent to humankind. To succumb to self-sufficiency. To assume the role of God.

God does not directly condemn this presumption. He allows us to perish, to collapse, and to suffer the consequences. This resonates with the legends of so many ancient dynasties and civilisations. Like the transformation of wild predators.

Without this awareness... humans are little more than hideous beasts.’

Gold/Richter nodded silently. Certain words of Apollo’s came back to him. A hint of decency flitted across his face.

Before walking away, he said:

“Professor... I too have made mistakes, against my will. But the one I hurt... has forgiven me. I believe Red would handle this better. And that he would do the same for you.”

Oak lowered his eyes slightly.

“...I hope you’re right.”

An elderly woman’s voice rang out behind them.

“For that, an old man like you needs some company...”

Oak was more startled than Gold/Richter. Two figures were already standing there. Agatha. Lorelei.

Gold/Richter recognised them.

“You are...”

Agatha spoke first.

BGM ‘Rebellion’ 00:00–02:23

“I have been living here, incognito. Lorelei, on the other hand, has come here specifically.”

Lorelei nodded.

“We have come on Lance’s behalf.”

Gold/Richter understood. He asked no further questions.

Agatha looked at Oak.

‘I’m not claiming to be young any more. It’s more that you... you’ve grown old. Not physically. Mentally.

You're looking back at past glories rather than towards the future. As if you were immortal. You're no longer as suited to young people. Nor to humans. Nor to Pokémon."

Oak gave a self-deprecating smile.

"It's a pleasure to see that an old rival has faded so much."

Agatha shook her head slightly.

BGM 'Rebellion' 01:13–02:23

"I expected it to be a delight to see you like this.

But responsibilities, devotion to science... have stripped you of your prowess. Have made you rusty. Have brought about this senility, this obstinacy."

I have pushed that notion from my thoughts. Some might still find pleasure in it. Not me.

'You often don't realise just how much you put pressure on yourself and make yourself so rigid. You need company.'

Oak said nothing more. An involuntary look of resignation crossed his face.

Agatha turned to Gold/Richter.

'With young people, we worry that they're still immature, that they haven't made good use of their time, even though they still have plenty left.

With the elderly, we worry that they have squandered too much, and no longer have enough left to keep growing.

Oak's state serves as a fitting driving force for his own generation.

As for me... I have withdrawn to watch over the newcomer. And the one of a different origin."

Lorelei then spoke, her voice colder, more precise.

"Young people typically have no need for my coldness. But those who have overcome Johto's Ice Master and absorbed his wisdom... my knowledge may be of use. Sober. Valuable. Sometimes sharp.

Especially when time is of the essence."

Gold/Richter said almost nothing.

A sombre sense of relief settled within him. Not a definitive one. Simply the feeling that he would no longer have to face what remained entirely alone.

Twilight continued to deepen around the laboratory.

End of scene

Scene — The Sorrowful Interception

Oak Laboratory Office — *a spring evening, 6–7 pm*

The artificial light was dim. Shadows stretched long across the shelves and the switched-off equipment. Outside, the spring twilight was fading away.

Gold/Richter stood there, still on edge from having been summoned.

BGM 'EP04 S01 03:47–05:00'

"Why was I summoned?"

Oak didn't reply straight away. He adjusted something on the large computer screen.

"It wasn't appropriate to explain it to you in front of the ladies."

He sat up slightly.

"It's the usual time Red calls."

Gold/Richter stood motionless; the anomaly struck him like a tonne of bricks.

Oak added, in a lower voice:

'Admittedly, this breaches confidentiality. But if certain aspects take precedence over mere data... for you... this exception is justifiable.

Under no circumstances must you be detected by the screen. Measure your distance carefully."

Gold/Richter nodded. Stunned, he could barely speak. Oak read his silence and did not press for any further formalities.

The call appeared suddenly. A connection request.

Oak made a silent, precise gesture. Gold/Richter immediately took cover in the indicated corner. The position was safe. But the viewing angle remained imperfect, and the voice would only reach him partially, muffled.

Oak accepted the call.

BGM "EP05 S02 14:12 15:37"

Red's image appeared.

Gold/Richter stared at him.

Physically, Red looked fit. He hadn't lost weight. No visible injuries. No obvious signs of decline. Yet something was missing. His usual liveliness was absent. An indescribable sharpness, difficult to pinpoint, but present in the way he filled the screen, in the minimalism of his movements, in the little he let on.

Oak took the initiative. His voice remained calm, almost ritualistic. Short sentences. Superficial questions. Remarks that required almost no elaborate response.

From where he sat, Gold/Richter could see that Red spoke very little.

It was not a loss of the ability to speak. It was a reluctance. A remorse that could not be resolved. He did not completely cut off the exchange — out of a residual sense of affability, out of the weight of a relationship that was still beyond repair. But he spoke little. Because Oak himself did not provide enough substance, or enough substance to last long enough, for Red to be able to respond properly.

Oak took care not to overwhelm him. He sidestepped anything that might have untangled a knot that was too sensitive. The conversation seemed to serve mainly to verify one thing: that Red was still there, still able to carry on.

Gold/Richter watched.

He was more distressed by this particular change—by this carefully maintained void—than if he had seen Red physically injured or openly broken.

His face, in the half-light, bore a heavy, almost oppressive melancholy as he observed this half-inaudible, ceremonious and hollow conversation.

The exchange continued for a few more moments without anything of substance coming across the screen.

Gold/Richter didn't move. He continued to stare at what remained of Red's voice.

End of scene

Scene — The Terror of Organic Savagery

Mt. Silver Hillside — *early summer, 6–7 pm*

The fragmented snow still hung in the air. Beneath their footsteps, it gave way with a dull thud. Red was making his way down. Pikachu walked alongside him. The sense of calm was relative, but real.

BGM 'EP03 S01 15:35 16:22'

Then the atmosphere changed.

It wasn't a scream. Not a visible movement. Just an amorphous presence, a low, membranous expanse that suddenly filled the space.

Red halted. Pikachu pricked up its ears. The instinct for danger kicked in immediately.

The rustling sounds grew louder in bursts, then faded almost entirely.

Suddenly.

A Golbat entered their field of vision and stared.

Mean Look.

The effect took hold instantly. Red and Pikachu were caught off guard. Such precision, from what must have been a wild Pokémon, was almost unprecedented.

Golbat did not wait. A ghostly light shot upwards, following an erratic trajectory that was difficult to anticipate.

Confuse Ray.

BGM 'EP04 S02 14:40–15:00'

Pikachu dodged once. Twice. The residual blast hit it. Its step became hesitant.

Red observed, unable to reach a conclusion: Confuse Ray was biologically possible. Yet at this level, among the local population, it remained rare. The doubt lingered, subtle.

Before Pikachu could regain its balance, Golbat sliced through the air.

Air Slash.

The image was distorted. Golbat vanished down the slope as suddenly as it had appeared.

Same slope — mid-summer

The light was warmer. The air remained crisp and alpine. Red was making his way down, Venusaur at his side. Relative tranquillity.

The incursion came without the same prelude.

BGM 'Black Eyes'.

A Misdreavus lunged forward with calculating malice, showing no sign of having been tamed.

Red made a brief gesture. Venusaur released **Sleep Powder**.

The wind picked up too strongly, too precisely, and scattered the powder. Misdreavus was barely affected.

It stared at Venusaur.

Mean Look.

Red sensed the familiar pattern. Something inside him tensed.

Venusaur responded without further command. **Sludge Bomb**.

Misdreavus was hit hard. It held firm. Then, without delay, it used **Pain Split**.

It was not outright pain. It was an inner deprivation, a subversion, as if something essential had just been taken away. Suffocating. Without any spectacular injury.

Misdreavus didn't wait. **Perish Song**.

The pressure doubled. Mean Look and **Perish Song**.

Red did not hesitate. He ordered **Giga Drain**, a clear gamble to prevent time from running out.

Misdreavus was neutralised. Mean Look wore off. A fleeting sense of relief washed over him — a fragile one.

Red prepared to recall Venusaur to counteract what remained of Perish Song.

A Golbat appeared out of nowhere.

Red anticipated the move. He recalled Venusaur. He was almost in time: Venusaur returned to his Poké Ball before the combination of Mean Look and Perish Song could strike him.

But there were no more Pokémon outside.

Golbat stared at Red.

Mean Look.

The effect took hold of him immediately.

Red sent out Charizard.

BGM 'Black Eyes' 01:35—the end

Golbat unleashed **Haze** without restraint. The black mist thickened, obscuring landmarks and levelling the playing field.

Even hidden within the fog, the effect of Mean Look on Red remained active. A dull, oppressive weight. A terror that would not fade.

Red and Charizard searched. The membranous form moved through the mist with a cunning too precise for a mere wild Pokémon.

Silence.

Then Golbat burst out of the darkness with the relentless determination of a predator lunging to drain, to feast.

The air grew still once more. The weight of Mean Look still hung heavy.

BGM 'Eclipse' 03:04—end

End of episode

Close of episode

Totals

≈ 11,000 words · 33 pp. A4 · read aloud ≈ 75 min.

Pass 1/3 — still open

Metalepsis 09. conjecture / sketched / was articulating. Gold/Richter only. Dracula title = piece as well as scene. Notes moved here. P1: Night Owl → Night-Walker; Fighting → Physical; curse → imprecation (×3); Chris he → she; Johto his → its; moods → poorly prepared; Disheartening → Desolate; question-title → statement.

Version notes

2026-09-24 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. Traces = address. Golbat left open. Author filled. Title: Human Beings Are Stupid. Don't Leave Me as in the body (FR fiche: Please Don't Leave Me). Softening, virgin soil and cruel wisdom paid forward.

Open for what follows

The gadgets · Red · Mean Look on the Trainer · the network on the slope.

BGM credits

Pieces: Castlevania: Nocturne (Netflix), Trevor Morris & Trey Toy. Traces: duration only.